

Sunday, July 8th Evening (14 min.)

[GRISWALD]

This is for him. He loved these. We called them “Griswalds” before they were widely known as selfies. Also, he would want to know who was here.

Before I continue, I want to take one more moment to thank the incredible generosity of Jim and Rebecca Long. Jim and Rebecca, your magnanimity has known no bounds. Moreover, your Hotel Albuquerque staff has shown such compassion and competence -- Katie, Adrian, Jesse, Gilbert, Beth. I'm sure I'm missing several other names.

I also want to take a moment to thank Aunt Karen for spearheading this event. She has a small army too -- Alexis, Jane, Helen. From start to finish, Aunt Karen, your effort has been an obvious labor of love, and it is a clear testament to how you cherished, and will continue to cherish your brother.

I've heard it said that heaven will have to expand a little to accommodate my father's grand personality. I've heard it said that he has left a hole that cannot be filled. I've also heard it said that my father continues to talk with some of you, as he continues to be present with me.

I do not, though, think any words or expressed sentiment can truly capture the magnitude of his loss. It is massive, and it is final.

And yet the legacy of my father, I've heard now time and again, was how he delivered his special light to each of our lives. How he lifted us up, how he inspired us, how he carried us. And so it seems more appropriate to celebrate his light than to dwell on his absence.

And what a light it was. Polychromatic, phosphorescent, ever-changing.

I'm not sure any one of us knew my father completely. He was too complex of a being. But a few qualities stand out clearly enough for me to remember here and now.

My father lived lucky. Cards would fall in his favor. His mother said he had the Midas touch. When I was younger, this used to frustrate me to no end. How did he always seem to come out on top and with a big smile?

It later became clear to me that my father created his luck. I remember the first time this hit home, when I heard the Jefferson quote “I'm a firm believer in luck, and I find the harder I work, the luckier I get.”

My father's work ethic and drive were peerless. They were a derivative of his passions, to be sure. But they defined all that he did. When I joined him for projects, we would be up at 6am and

in at 9pm, and all the day we'd be working. He'd work smart, not hard, but he'd work hard too. And as a genuine renaissance man, he could do nearly everything on his own, and so he did. Actually, he didn't just do it. He *overdid* it. Because, to quote: "If it's worth doing, it's worth overdoing."

My father was also an unyielding romantic and visionary. He imagined in ideals. Day in, and day out, he saw what others did not, or could not.

His romanticism combined with his work ethic made my Dad an out-and-out World Builder. He envisioned a prouder lobo club, a more distinct village. He dreamt up Hacienda Tranquilo, and Fly Hook Lodge. He sort of fell in love with each of these projects, saw their idealized potential, and then could not rest until his vision matched the reality in front of him. Similarly, my father grew frustrated when he witnessed others settle for less than his grandiose expectations.

My father's romanticism was infectious, if not downright inspiring. You didn't want to live in your world. You wanted to live in his. "My life is a vacation" he would say. And indeed, to him, every single day was an adventure.

If a lucky romantic, my father was also a joiner. He got involved. At social gatherings, he engaged everyone within his view. This sometimes manifested as merciless but good-hearted teasing. Importantly, he spoke to you regardless of rank or status. Anyone could be his friend.

In life, just as one example, his ownership over a small community issue would snowball into a full-blown Mayorship. Whether the lobo club, the University, or the village, I think his pride in the communities he joined was so strong in part because his built pride in self was so strong. Certainly, these two prides, community and self, did create a virtuous cycle.

These natural qualities -- this drive, romance, and joining -- made my father a model community member and natural leader. One of my professors at Business School speaks of leadership as an earned responsibility to influence the reality of those you lead. My father did this. He envisioned a world that we wanted to live in; he worked his ass off to build it; and he invited us to participate.

But then I think what made him just so special -- what was part and parcel with his drive, romance, and joining -- was just how quirky, rich, and endless his inner life was.

I'm not sure I ever fully knew what my father was thinking. My father's favorite book was Jonathan Livingston Seagull. It begins: "But way off alone, out by himself beyond boat and shore, Jonathan Livingston Seagull was practicing."

My father often practiced, on his own. When he was young, he would throw free throws until he hit so many in a row. He'd hit a tennis ball endlessly against a wall. He'd kick a football as high and as straight as he could into the air, then catch it.

Jonathan Livingston Seagull goes on to tell the story of a gull who is bored with daily squabbles over food. He is seized by a passion for flight, and he pushes himself, learning everything he can about flying. So too my father, seized by his passions, would become obsessed with perfecting technique.

I think it was this dedicated practicing that allowed him to quickly find talent in all that he did. This self-play. He could get lost in anything -- golf, construction, cars, finance, fishing, operations, photography. It was these techniques -- constantly in the process of perfecting -- that my father employed quite literally in building my world, in shaping each of our realities.

And because he could find a kind of play in all that he did, because he could exhibit playfulness and unrivaled creativity at peak competence -- and even in the midst of dramatic hardship, because he did know hard times -- his life appeared a kind of breeze, an easy vacation.

And we wanted to play with *him*.

In the book, Jonathan ultimately eschews a life of higher and faster flying to return to the flocks to teach others how to fly higher and faster. And I have often thought, that even if my father did not know it, and even if we or I did not comprehend the full message, that he in his inner life was teaching us, too. He was teaching us to live wholeheartedly, joyfully, determinedly, and certainly with a kind of flair. As for myself, I know his teaching will be with me for the remainder of my life.

Of course, many people could have told you some of these things I did -- about my father's energy, vision, and joy, his play -- in their own words. But even if none of these things were true, what I can say about my father, uniquely, what I will always remember about him, and what stings so much about his loss, is that he was a good Dad. This is the highest praise I can offer.

With his father, he would build worlds in the woods where he and I could fish and explore and merely be out in the great wilderness. Then again, recently, he was building an incredible fly fishing lodge, where he and I could fish the river peaceably.

He'd drive us on long RV trips to tennis tournaments or family vacations.

He built this palace that would become a sanctuary for my high-school friends to have innocent fun. He would generously cook my friends, or any teammates of mine, fat steaks and we would play -- carefree -- basketball, pool, poker, and then hours of video games.

He hurried out to San Francisco to help build a sturdy foundation for me in an all-too-big and uncertain City. We would find a studio apartment together. He would build me a mini yoga studio with hardwood floors and mirrors, and a sound-insulated booth to sing.

He then joined me on no less than three occasions to discuss my radical aversion to a prestigious career track. And even though he didn't understand, he ultimately supported me as I took a left turn into riding a bicycle taxi. He would later visit our small pedicab shop to help better organize our inventory with Costco shelving.

When I later struggled with City roommates, he rushed back to San Francisco in with a 40ft RV packed with building material so that we could renovate the stable-turned-Carriage-House that Mimosa and I now called home. He was determined that I have a stable and peaceful nest.

When I finally made it to an advanced degree, even though simply saying "Stanford" became shorthand for his pride in me -- and I know that he loved brands -- I never questioned whether his pride was attached to the name brand.

Just as he did with any of his projects, he brought to bare all of himself, all of his romanticism, work ethic, and involvement on being the best father he could be. He, along with my mother, built our family's world. And a beautiful world it was, and is.

Dad, you were my foundation, safety net, arch support, model, guide, inspiration, visionary. And as an only-child, you were for me a lifelong best friend. I was not nearly finished downloading your wisdom, seeking your advice, or merely sharing in your company. You always knew how to turn what first looked like a problem into an opportunity. You knew how to touch something, and make it gold. You knew how to build a sense of place and home.

You forced joy and pride and integrity into this world. You showed us all that life can be — why wouldn't it be? — a grand adventure. Even with your gregariousness that could border on brash, you surprised me, again and again, at your ability to be wise, and to be big-hearted.

Thank you for teaching me, for teaching us, and for shining your beautiful, complicated light.

A wise friend told me that you already knew all that I would become, that you had already imbued me with all of your dreams. I recognize that how I choose to live my life will be your testament.

You live in me, in us. But I am not the same -- we are not the same -- without you.